

Asia Chart Alert

Global Markets Research

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Economics - Asia ex-Japan

China: Current account surplus increased slightly in Q1

... supported by smaller services deficit, but trade surplus remained unchanged.

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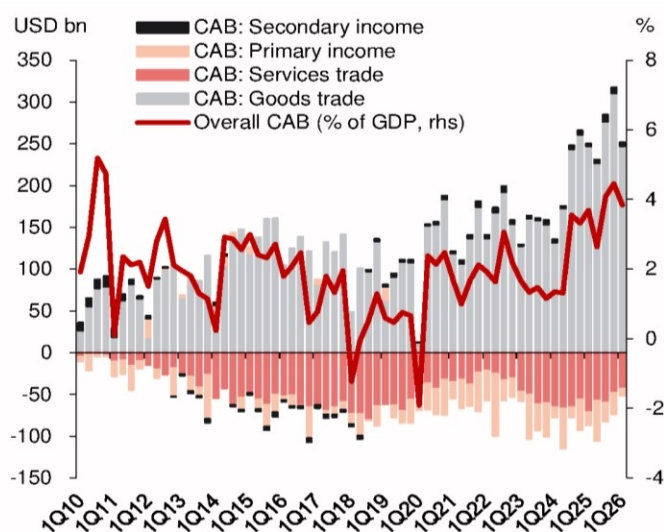
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Fig. 1: A breakdown of China's current account balance



- Preliminary balance of payments data from SAFE show China's current account surplus dropped from the record high of USD242bn in Q4 2025 to USD184bn in Q1 2026. Still, it is above USD164bn in Q1 2025. The surplus to GDP ratio accordingly fell to 3.8% in Q1 from 4.4% in Q4.
- The goods trade surplus in Q1 was unchanged from last year's USD247bn, despite a slightly narrower customs trade surplus of USD264bn from USD271bn. Following our latest upwardly revised export and import growth forecasts, we expect the trade surplus to narrow to USD1,161bn in 2026 from USD1,185bn in 2025. The current account surplus to GDP ratio is thus expected to edge down to 3.6% in 2026 from 3.7% in 2025.
- Services trade deficit narrowed to USD44bn in Q1 from USD72bn in Q1 2025, with the deficit in tourism services contracting to USD47bn from USD60bn.
- On the financial account, FDI recovered to USD34bn in Q1 from USD15bn a year earlier, while ODI declined to USD44bn from USD50bn. Based on data of onshore bank FX receipts and payments, portfolio investment net outflows increased to USD53bn in Q1 from USD27bn a year earlier.

Note: The Q1 2026 print refers to advance estimates.

Source: SAFE, Nomura Global Economics.

Appendix A-1

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